

Wilderfolk — Global Creative Brainstorm Report

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Scope: Whole game: simulation, settlement strategy, people, ecology, stories, diplomacy, defense, presentation, replayability, and long-term identity.

Method: Affinity Diagrams / KJ Method, developed by **Jiro Kawakita**. Existing game capabilities, audit findings, roadmap items, and player-facing frictions were atomized into observations, clustered by emergent relationship, and then recombined into feature directions. The purpose is not to produce a longer feature list. It is to find the few ideas that make Wilderfolk feel more like one coherent living world.

Central creative thesis: Wilderfolk should become a game about reading the consequences of a settlement’s choices. The strongest future features are not isolated systems; they are connective tissue that lets food, work, roads, family, weather, stories, animals, rivals, and memory visibly affect one another.

1. What was deliberately refused

The first obvious directions were rejected because they would add surface area without increasing the game’s identity. Wilderfolk does not need a generic technology tree, a disconnected crafting menu, a conventional quest board, or a large collection of unrelated buildings. It also does not need more hidden simulation complexity before existing complexity becomes legible to the player.

The brainstorm therefore avoids proposing “more content” as the default answer. Each idea below must have a specific mechanism, a reason it belongs in Wilderfolk, a first implementation slice, and an honest trade-off. At least one idea in every cluster is grounded enough to build without inventing a new simulation owner or cadence.

2. Affinity map: the surprising shape of the game

The source material naturally formed eight clusters. They are not conventional code modules. They describe the player’s experience of the valley.

Cluster	What the player is really trying to understand	Opportunity exposed
The Valley Explains Itself	Why is this person, building, resource, or story in this state?	A shared read-only “Why?” language across every inspector and warning.

The Day Has a Rhythm	What changed since yesterday, and what deserves attention now?	A daily council/reporting rhythm that turns simulation cadence into planning.
People Are Routes, Not Rows	How do work, home, love, family, fatigue, and scandal shape movement?	Human lives that can be followed as chains of intention rather than isolated statuses.
The Settlement Has a Nervous System	Where is the colony under pressure before the crisis becomes visible?	Operations, logistics, and early-warning tools that connect distant systems.
Nature Is a Negotiating Partner	Is the valley a stockpile, a threat, or a living relationship?	Ecology-first decisions where care, extraction, weather, and wildlife produce recognizable consequences.
Stories Leave Scars	Why does this settlement feel different from another seed?	Memory, legacy, and recurring consequences built from existing events and flags.
The Frontier Has Social Consequences	What does defense, diplomacy, and suspicion do to ordinary life?	Frontier choices that change routines, trust, architecture, and relationships, not only combat numbers.
Time Is a Material	Can a player understand what changed across days, seasons, and generations?	Replay, comparison, seasonal transitions, and visible historical layers.

The clusters reveal a gap between **simulation richness** and **player-readable causality**. Wilderfolk already has many of the ingredients for a distinctive colony story. The next creative phase should make those ingredients touch each other in visible, recoverable ways.

3. Cluster One — The Valley Explains Itself

3.1 The Shared “Why?” Layer — Grounded first slice

Create one presentation language for explanations. Selecting a settler, building, resource, story choice, or warning shows three compact lines: **Current state**, **Reason**, and **Next useful action**. For example: “Commuting to the farm. Shift started at 07:00, but the north gate is blocked. Open the gate or assign a nearer worker.” A story card might say: “Choice unavailable. The village has 4 of 6 required grain. Keep the card and recover grain.”

This is not a new simulation owner. It is a family of typed read-only projections over existing authoritative state. The first slice should cover selected settlers, blocked story choices,

staffing rejection, and movement interruption. The feature is valuable because it makes many unrelated systems feel like one game.

Trade-off: Explanations can become noisy or falsely certain. Every message should distinguish known facts from an interpretation, and it should prefer “currently blocked by” over invented narrative certainty.

3.2 The Movement Sentence

Replace a flat activity label with a short, changing sentence assembled from real state:

“Leaving home for the bakery,” “Waiting outside the closed tavern,” “Rerouting around the sealed west gate,” “Returning home because the shift ended.” The sentence should update only on meaningful transition, not every tick, and preserve the previous transition for inspection.

First slice: A five-entry movement trace for the selected human, backed by existing movement and pathfinding state.

Failure mode: The trace may look authoritative while omitting a low-level cause. It must show uncertainty or “reason unavailable” rather than fabricate a reason.

3.3 The Blocked-Action Anatomy

When an action fails, show the failure as a small anatomy diagram: **requirement**, **current value**, **shortfall**, and **recovery route**. This should work for staffing, story choices, construction, housing, animal care, and diplomacy. A red “no” becomes a planning object.

The creative opportunity is to make failure useful. A shortage is not just a prohibition; it is a visible route toward a future choice.

4. Cluster Two — The Day Has a Rhythm

4.1 The Daily Council Report — Grounded first slice

At the daily boundary, the player receives a calm, expandable report titled with the day and season. It contains only meaningful changes: net food, housing pressure, new births and deaths, major relationship events, story movement, threats, animal-care warnings, and unresolved blocked actions. Each row links to the responsible person, building, resource, or card.

The report should not add a new cadence. It consumes the existing daily result and gives the player a planning moment. The smallest version can be a single panel with seven categories and a “show only changes” filter.

Trade-off: A report can become a spreadsheet. Prioritize three levels: “needs attention,” “changed,” and “quiet.” Do not report every simulated event.

4.2 The Three-Clock Forecast

Give the player three horizons instead of one warning list: **Now** (current blockage), **Soon** (likely pressure within two days), and **Season** (structural risk before the next seasonal turn). Example: “Now: 2 workers are idle,” “Soon: stored grain reaches reserve floor,” “Season: the mountain road becomes unreliable in winter.”

This turns the simulation into anticipation rather than reaction. Forecast entries should be derived from existing trends and thresholds, not from a hidden oracle.

Trade-off: Forecasts can feel like the game is solving strategy for the player. Show the signal and confidence— “based on current consumption” —and let the player decide what matters.

4.3 The Settlement Weather Vane

A single visual object in the village—such as a cloth vane, bell board, or smoke column—changes according to broad colony conditions: contentment, hunger pressure, danger, and social strain. It does not replace numbers; it gives the settlement an emotional barometer.

This idea is intentionally atmospheric. It would make the valley readable at a glance without adding another panel, but it should be added only after the underlying metrics are stable and explainable.

5. Cluster Three — People Are Routes, Not Rows

5.1 Life Threads

When following a settler, show a horizontal “life thread” for the current day: **home → commute → work → meal → leisure → home**. Interruptions appear as knots: festival, illness, scandal, prison, blocked path, visitor, or Moon Howler transformation. The thread is not a rigid schedule; it is a readable projection of actual transitions.

The key design principle is that a settler becomes a person with intentions. A player can understand why two settlers meet, why a household is empty, or why a workplace is understaffed.

Trade-off: A timeline can imply a false determinism. Display actual transitions and planned targets separately, using different visual treatments.

5.2 Household Weather

Give each household a small changing condition based on existing family, housing, meal, work, relationship, and pregnancy state: **settled, stretched, celebrating, grieving, divided, or waiting**. The state should be a presentation summary, not a new mood simulation.

A household could be “stretched” because one adult is imprisoned, one child is working or studying, and food is tight. That makes family life strategically visible without adding dozens of hidden needs.

5.3 The Care Web

Represent care as a visible network rather than a private fact. A child, pregnant settler, elderly settler, injured worker, animal, or imprisoned family member can have nearby people whose routines provide support or create strain. The first slice need not add new care actions: it can show existing relationships and residence/work paths as a network in the inspector.

Later, a player might prioritize a nearby workplace, assign a household meal, or protect a caregiver’s schedule. The important idea is that settlement resilience emerges from relationships, not only from resource totals.

Trade-off: Care systems can become moral pressure or micromanagement. Keep the first implementation observational and allow the player to intervene only through existing workforce, housing, food, and schedule controls.

6. Cluster Four — The Settlement Has a Nervous System

6.1 Colony Operations Center — High-priority grounded feature

Build a compact operations center that answers three questions: **What is failing? What is about to fail? What can I do now?** It combines food, housing, workforce, threats, story gates, animal care, movement pressure, and unresolved warnings. Every concern links back to a person, building, card, or action.

The operations center is the most practical global feature because it does not require a new fantasy system. It is a coherent projection of existing truth. It should not be a giant dashboard; it should be a prioritized queue with a maximum of five urgent items and an optional “all signals” view.

Trade-off: It could flatten the game into optimization. Preserve ambiguity and local discovery by showing causes and options, not one recommended solution.

6.2 Pressure Map

Add a read-only map layer showing where the settlement is under strain: long commutes, blocked paths, low food access, housing overflow, defense gaps, wildlife pressure, or repeated workplace vacancies. Pressing a hotspot opens the relevant inspector.

The map should reveal spatial patterns that totals cannot: one side of town is thriving while the mountain road isolates three homes; a tavern draws workers away from a farm during harvest; a gate creates a daily bottleneck.

6.3 Workforce Policies as Civic Values

Turn auto-staffing presets into explicit civic values: **Survival**, **Growth**, **Defense**, and **Comfort**. Each preset compiles to existing workforce priorities and reserve thresholds. The player can override individuals manually, and the inspector always states which policy caused an assignment.

The more interesting version is that policy becomes part of settlement identity. A Survival colony may protect food reserves but create social fatigue; a Comfort colony may retain happier routines but lack emergency labor. These effects should emerge from existing assignment and schedule outcomes, not from a new hidden morality meter.

7. Cluster Five — Nature Is a Negotiating Partner

7.1 The Valley's Seasonal Bargain

Each season presents one visible ecological bargain drawn from existing ecology, food, weather, animals, and geography. For example: “The blueberry slopes are abundant, but harvesting them increases travel exposure,” or “Protecting the deer corridor reduces immediate meat but preserves next season's replenishment.”

The player chooses among two or three responses, but the consequences are delayed and legible. This could be implemented as authored story decisions that delegate effects to existing ecology owners.

Trade-off: The game could become too card-driven. Keep the bargains infrequent, tied to actual local conditions, and readable from the map.

7.2 Animal Care as a Relationship with Consequences

Post-taming care can grow beyond a warning state into a visible care contract: the animal has a habitat preference, feeding pressure, and trust history. A cared-for animal might improve scouting, hunting safety, or settlement morale; neglected care should produce warning, withdrawal, or ecological consequence rather than sudden punishment.

The first slice should expose the current care state, ration pressure, and recovery path in the animal inspector. The deeper system should wait until the basic state machine is

demonstrably reliable.

7.3 Wildlife Corridors

Use the map's mountain regions, forests, food chain, and hunting systems to create visible wildlife corridors. Roads, walls, gates, farms, and hunting pressure alter where animals appear. A corridor is not a new population simulation; it is a spatial projection and a bounded ecological decision.

This gives roads and walls a second meaning: infrastructure changes what the valley can sustain. It also creates a strong visual identity for Wilderfolk compared with generic grid colonies.

8. Cluster Six — Stories Leave Scars

8.1 Settlement Memory and Legacy Goals — Strong long-term foundation

Turn the Chronicle into a settlement identity page that records what this particular valley has endured: first winter, first election promise, first treaty, first Moon Howler, first child born, first shortage recovered, first family lost, first festival hosted, and first animal successfully cared for.

The memory should use existing story flags, event log entries, births, deaths, relationships, diplomacy, and seasonal state. It should not initially grant rewards. Its first purpose is to make a generated settlement feel authored by the player's history.

Trade-off: A list of achievements can feel like a checklist. Use short prose fragments and recurring names from the actual settlement.

8.2 Consequence Echoes

When a major story resolves, let its outcome reappear later as a small echo in ordinary life. A successful theatre company leaves a song in tavern dialogue. A deer decision changes a future hunting rumor. A wedding diplomacy chain affects which visitors are welcomed. A kept election promise changes a council report phrase.

The mechanism is a bounded event-to-presentation lookup table. It creates continuity without adding a new simulation subsystem.

8.3 The Rumour Ledger as a Social Mirror

Expand the rumour concept into a player-readable ledger that distinguishes **observed**, **believed**, and **confirmed** information. Rumors are generated only from real Chronicle or event facts, and each entry shows its source and current confidence.

The player could use rumors to decide whether to investigate an affair, trust a visitor, prepare for a rival, or ignore village anxiety. The important design constraint is that rumors should not become arbitrary misinformation; they should be imperfect social interpretations of actual events.

9. Cluster Seven — The Frontier Has Social Consequences

9.1 Defense Changes the Village's Personality

Walls, gates, watchtowers, patrols, prisons, and soldiers should visibly change daily life. A heavily defended settlement may have safer roads but longer gate queues, more patrol interruptions, and a different festival atmosphere. A lightly defended settlement may have freer movement but more uncertainty and diplomacy pressure.

The first slice is presentation: patrol presence, gate status, and defense posture appear in the Daily Council Report and movement trace. Later, existing schedules can respond through named commands and owners.

Trade-off: Defense should never become a hidden happiness penalty. Every social consequence must be visible, recoverable, and tied to a player choice.

9.2 The Frontier Hearing

After a raid, scandal, imprisonment, diplomatic incident, or major shortage, hold a short public hearing in the town hall. The player does not choose a binary good/evil verdict. Instead, they choose what the settlement wants to learn or protect: **security, mercy, truth, reputation, or recovery.**

The hearing projects existing evidence into a story decision and delegates consequences to the relevant owner. It creates civic drama from systems already present.

9.3 Rivalry Through Customs, Not Only Armies

Rival settlements can express rivalry through marriage customs, market etiquette, festivals, hunting boundaries, visitor treatment, and rumors—not only raids or diplomacy scores. A rival might send an awkward gift, invite a musician, challenge a hunting claim, or request a wedding concession.

This makes diplomacy feel like contact between cultures rather than a numeric relationship meter. The approved wedding and theatre story directions are strong foundations for this layer.

10. Cluster Eight — Time Is a Material

10.1 What Changed Since Yesterday? — Small, high-return feature

Add a comparison mode that overlays the previous daily state against the current one. It highlights changed homes, assignments, food pressure, relationship links, story progress, active warnings, and defenses. The player can inspect “before” and “after” without opening a developer console.

This feature also helps developers validate worker parity and save/load truth. It is a rare idea that improves both game feel and engineering confidence.

10.2 Seasonal Transition Montage

At a season boundary, show a short map-level transition: roads becoming muddy, mountain passes changing, children aging, animals shifting, crops changing color, and the settlement’s population line moving. The montage should be assembled from real state changes and skippable immediately.

The goal is not spectacle. It makes the daily cadence emotionally legible and gives long runs a sense of passage.

10.3 Generational Landmarks

Allow the settlement to accumulate named landmarks from actual history: “The Gate Where the Treaty Held,” “Mara’s Orchard,” “The Winter Road,” or “The Empty House.” Names can be generated from event type and real entities, with player confirmation before permanence.

A landmark is initially a Chronicle projection and map label. Later it could become a place where future stories reference the colony’s past. This gives the world continuity without requiring a complex quest system.

Trade-off: Automatic naming can produce embarrassing or repetitive results. Keep names editable or offer a small curated vocabulary.

11. Cross-cluster combinations with the highest potential

The most valuable ideas are combinations where one small projection makes several existing systems reinforce each other.

Combination	What it creates	Why it is powerful
Shared “Why?” Layer + Daily Council Report	A report where every warning has a cause and a clickable recovery path.	Converts information into action rather than more reading.

Life Threads + Pressure Map	The colony can be understood through both human routes and spatial bottlenecks.	Connects individual stories to infrastructure strategy.
Settlement Memory + Consequence Echoes	Past choices alter the language and atmosphere of later days.	Makes a seeded settlement feel uniquely authored.
Seasonal Bargains + Three-Clock Forecast	Ecology becomes a visible choice with preparation time.	Adds tension without hidden punishment.
Defense Posture + Household Weather	Military decisions become ordinary family and routine consequences.	Makes frontier strategy emotionally grounded.
What Changed + Worker/Save Truth	Players and developers can see whether the simulation stayed coherent.	Improves both trust and regression discovery.

12. Recommended creative direction

Wilderfolk’s distinctive lane is **a readable living settlement**, not the largest possible colony simulator. The game should make players feel that they are interpreting a valley whose systems are already in motion, then choosing where to intervene. A good feature does not merely add a new resource, unit, or menu. It reveals a relationship between things that were already there.

The strongest near-term direction is therefore a **Truth-to-Story Loop**:

Simulation produces change → the game explains the cause → the player chooses a response → the settlement remembers the consequence.

This loop can be built almost entirely from existing foundations. It also protects the project from the most dangerous failure mode identified in the audit: locally correct systems that are stale, invisible, or disconnected at the player-facing boundary.

13. Suggested delivery sequence

Horizon	Focus	Concrete outcome
First stabilization slice	Shared “Why?” Layer, blocked-action anatomy, selected-human movement sentence, and daily change summary.	A player can understand what a person or action is doing without opening debug logs.

Second slice	Colony Operations Center, Three-Clock Forecast, and Pressure Map.	The player can see current, emerging, and spatial problems in one calm surface.
Third slice	Settlement Memory, Consequence Echoes, and What Changed mode.	The valley develops a recognizable history and the player can compare its evolution.
Fourth slice	Workforce policies, seasonal bargains, and defense-social consequences.	Existing systems become strategic choices with visible trade-offs.
Later expansion	Care Web, wildlife corridors, frontier hearings, and generational landmarks.	The game gains deeper identity after truth, persistence, and readability are dependable.

14. Final shortlist: ten ideas worth carrying forward

1. **Shared “Why?” Layer** — the unifying presentation language for the whole game.
2. **Daily Council Report** — a planning rhythm built on the existing daily boundary.
3. **Colony Operations Center** — a calm prioritized answer to “what needs attention?”
4. **Life Threads** — a human-readable route through work, home, relationships, and interruption.
5. **Pressure Map** — spatial strategy from commute, food access, gates, roads, and defense.
6. **Settlement Memory and Legacy Goals** — a history that belongs to this settlement only.
7. **Consequence Echoes** — authored events that continue to color ordinary life.
8. **Seasonal Bargains** — ecology-first choices with preparation windows and delayed consequences.
9. **What Changed Since Yesterday?** — a compact comparison mode for trust, replay, and debugging.
10. **Defense Changes the Village’s Personality** — frontier choices expressed through everyday routines.

References

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